

TIMING THE BIG STEP

When should you walk into your boss's office, close the door, sit down, and tell him you quit?

Timing is one of life's great crap shoots. When we change our lives we tremble inside, like a gunslinger in a new town trembles no matter how many targets he's hit. But since I retired in 1984 I've talked to perhaps twenty-five people about very early retirement. Five of those people have since retired. Those five taught me three things about timing.

First, the right time to retire comes after you've started mental preparations. That's why the two-year test is so important. The test helps you focus on whether and when you might want to break your present routine. Second, the right time to retire comes before you're fully ready. The key word here is *fully*. You'll always harbor some doubt when you make such an important change. Third, the right time to retire is fairly obvious when it happens. It sort of jumps up and bites you.

Let me tell the stories of the five newly retired people I know. In each case the timing seems to follow a natural course, from mental preparation to the big break.

Harold is 39 and single. He worked in an oil company's treasury department. Harold's a quiet, careful plodder rather than a high-charged superstar. He prefers to talk about his summers in the south of France than his next career move. While at the office he used to dream about living in Cannes, Antibes, or Saint Raphael full time rather than for four weeks in July.

Harold's break came in September 1986. The oil company announced a program to encourage senior employees to retire. Although only 39, Harold had been with the company two weeks longer than the minimum to qualify under the program. He needed to save a bit more to hit his target net worth, but he decided to accept the offer anyway. He sold his condo, blue Toyota, and quarter share of a ski cabin. He